PRIORITY 27 OF 33 · SCORE 2.3

Interior

Interior's distinctive fraud risk is on the revenue side: companies underreporting oil, gas and coal royalties owed on federal and tribal land. Interior publishes company-level revenue data, which makes a public screen possible. Its spending side (tribal programs, wildfire, land management contracts) looks like other grant and contract work.

INVESTIGATIONS WE PROPOSE

- **DOI-1** Royalty per unit outliers by company and basin. **First prototype.**
- **DOI-2** C1 screen on wildfire and land management contracts.

EXPOSURE

- $37B in outlays and $97B in budgetary resources in FY2026.
- Royalty underpayment and valuation disputes are recurring False Claims Act and Office of Natural Resources Revenue enforcement matters.
- Tribal grant and contract programs have recurring OIG findings.

PUBLIC DATA WE USE

- **Natural Resources Revenue Data (ONRR):** revenue by company, commodity, location and year; production by lease.
- **USAspending and FPDS** for grants and contracts.
- **DOI OIG reports** and DOJ settlements.

HOW WE DETECT IT

1. **Royalty gaps:** companies whose reported royalty per unit of production falls well below peers in the same basin and period.
2. **Contractor screen:** the shared SAM.gov and FPDS checks applied to wildfire and land management contracts.

FIRST PROTOTYPE

A royalty-rate outlier table by company and basin from ONRR public data.

SCORECARD

Fraud savings identified
● Pending

Phase 1 window
Weeks 12–14
Feb 1, 2027 to Feb 19, 2027

Workstream
Aggregate screens and access cases

FY2026 outlays
$36.8B · budget rank 17

Leads go to
ONRR, DOI OIG

WHY PRIORITY 27

Exposure	●●○○○
Public data	●●●○○
SBA method fit	●●○○○
Actionability	●●○○○

OUR REVIEW, DELIVERED WEEK 14

Royalty-rate outlier table from ONRR Natural Resources Revenue Data (royalty per unit of production by company, commodity, basin and year); contractor screen on wildfire and land management contracts (C1).

Every lead goes to an Inspector General or DOJ as a referral package with sources and caveats. Nothing is published.

WHAT WE ASK OF INTERIOR

Phase 2 data: Lease-level sales and valuation data.

What it enables: Royalty underpayment at the lease level.

Access route: ONRR; DOI OIG.

LIMITS

Company-level revenue is aggregated; lease-level sales prices are not public. Valuation rules are complex, so outliers need expert review.

SOURCES

- Natural Resources Revenue Data
- USAspending agency profiles (FY2026 outlays)

Scores and plans are our judgment from public sources. Risk indicators are leads for Inspectors General or DOJ, not accusations.

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